

ORATORIO derives its name from the oratory (*a chapel in a church*) in which a monk, Fillipo Neri, used to deliver his sermons on Biblical history during the Sixteenth Century. These discourses were illustrated by sacred songs. The modern oratorio consists of solos, duets, broad majestic choruses and recitatives with full orchestral accompaniment. It is distinguished from opera by the absence of action, costumes, and scenery. Usually the



Oratorio at the Bach Festival

story is based on some text from the Bible. In the Eighteenth Century, Bach, Handel and Haydn developed the oratorio to its high standard.

The Messiah was written by George Frideric Handel, a German composer, who spent many years in England and who lies buried in Westminster Abbey. The story concerns the prophecies and coming of Jesus. It is said that Handel wrote this long oratorio in twenty-four days. When a great choir sang the *Hallelujah Chorus* at a performance of the *Messiah* in London, King George II and his nobles rose to their feet to show their reverence for this great music. The entire audience stood up with him and to this very day, it is customary for an audience to stand during the singing of this chorus.

Hallelujah Chorus

Handel (1685-1741)

Allegro